

Diplodocoids

The diplodocoids were a group of giant plant-eating dinosaurs that walked on all fours. They had incredibly long necks, balanced by even longer whiplike tails, which they used to lash out at enemies. Their legs were longer at the back than the front, which may have helped them to stand up, using the tail as a prop. One of the largest diplodocoids was *Amphicoelias*—a dinosaur as long as a football field and as heavy as a blue whale.



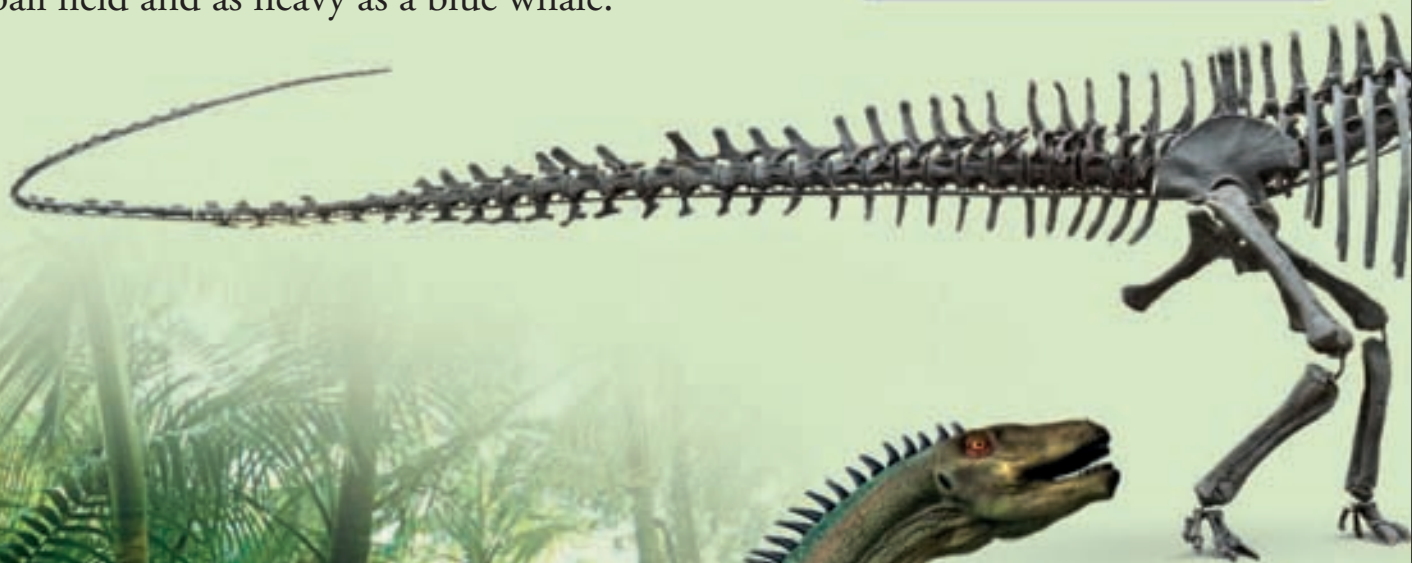
FAMILY FACT FILE

Key features

- Long, flexible necks
- Long, slender tails
- Small heads and large bodies

When

Diplodocoids first appeared in the Middle Jurassic, 170 million years ago. They died out at the start of the Late Cretaceous, 99 million years ago.



Dicraeosaurus

DIE-cray-oh-SORE-us



- **When** 150 million years ago (Late Jurassic)
- **Fossil location** Tanzania
- **Habitat** Woodlands
- **Length** 39 ft (12 m)
- **Diet** Plants

Dicraeosaurus had a shorter neck than other diplodocoids, so it probably fed on bushes rather than trees. Its tail was also shorter, which suggests it wasn't used like a whip. A layer of skin may have stretched between bony spines that ran along the dinosaur's neck and back, forming a sail. This perhaps helped to regulate body temperature, or it may have been used for defense or communicating with other members of the species.